Location Audio Audit Checklist

Use before every interview, stand-up, or location recording. Check items, correct problems, then record a test.

Location / scene: _____ Date / time: _____ Producer / operator: _____

1. Listen to the location

- ☐ Monitor on closed-back headphones before setup; note the ambient noise floor.
- ☐ Check for echo or harsh reflections; move away from bare walls, glass, and hard corners.
- ☐ Identify HVAC, appliances, traffic, crowds, hums, alarms, and intermittent noise.
- ☐ Ask to pause controllable noise; silence phones and noisy equipment when practical.

2. Wind and environment

- ☐ Check for wind at the mic position, not just where the operator is standing.
- ☐ Use a sheltered position or turn talent/mic away from gusts when possible.
- ☐ Fit suitable foam or furry wind protection; secure it and check it does not rub.
- ☐ Check clothing, jewelry, handling, cables, stands, and boom movement for rustle or bumps.

3. Microphone, placement, and signal path

- ☐ Choose mic and pickup pattern for distance, movement, background noise, and room acoustics.
- ☐ Confirm cable/transmitter, input, channel, battery, wireless connection, and phantom power if required.
- ☐ Record a test and listen back for distortion, hiss, hum, dropouts, wind, echo, and clothing noise.
- ☐ Place mic close and aimed correctly; keep it out of frame and away from reflective surfaces.
- ☐ Set input gain with talent speaking at real performance volume; leave headroom and avoid clipping.
- ☐ Watch meters throughout; keep peaks below 0 dBFS. Aim around -12 to -6 dBFS peaks when suitable for the recorder and assignment.

4. Before leaving

- ☐ Record 30-60 seconds of room tone / ambient sound without speaking or moving.
- ☐ Confirm files are recording, then check playback and backup/media status.

> **Fix first, then record:** If the sound is poor, reposition talent or mic, reduce controllable noise, add wind protection, or choose a quieter location. Do not rely on editing to repair clipping or severe wind.

Notes / corrective action

Gain meters and target levels vary by recorder and workflow. Follow equipment guidance; avoid clipping and verify every setup with headphones.